As public anger mounted, a manhunt was launched to nab the juvenile's father, Vishal Agrawal, for allowing his son access to the vehicle. He was arrested from Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar on May 21. Later, the son's bail was cancelled and he was sent to an observation home. In a stunning twist, his grandfather Surendrakumar—one of the four sons of Bramhadutt Agrawal, after whom the Bramha Group is named—was arrested for allegedly kidnapping the family driver to coerce him into claiming responsibility. The family had made its fortune in real estate, riding Pune's IT boom, and wields considerable clout. Surendrakumar had been previously charge-sheeted for ordering a hit on a Shiv Sena leader. The case, which involved underworld don Chhota Rajan, is at the trial stage.

Allegations of collusion grew as two doctors—Dr Ajay Taware, who heads the forensic science department, and chief medical officer Dr Shrihari Halnor—besides a peon were arrested for allegedly swapping the juvenile's blood sample at state-run Sassoon Hospital. Adding to MLA Tingre's troubles, a letter surfaced suggesting that he had lobbied for Dr Taware's appointment as the hospital's medical superintendent in December last year. Tingre denies exerting any pressure in the present case, claiming that he had visited the accident spot and the police station as a "responsible public representative".

As scrutiny intensified, a pattern of systemic rot emerged. Bars were sealed for serving minors. Two cops were suspended for alleged lapses. Ten arrests were made by May 28. Deputy chief minister Devendra Fadnavis, who holds the home portfolio, has described the JJB's "lenient view" as "shocking"—"one that created questions in the mind of the citizens and the government". He asserted that the police are now seeking to get the juvenile tried as an adult. According to Pune police commissioner Amitesh Kumar, their case against the juvenile did not rest on him causing a fatal accident under the influence of alcohol, but on the more stringent culpable homicide charge—punishable with up to a 10-year imprisonment. "He committed the act in full knowledge that it could lead to a loss of life," asserted Kumar. "Here, the alcohol content in the blood is not important."

DEPUTY CM DEVENDRA FADNAVIS ASSERTED THAT THE POLICE WANT THE ACCUSED JUVENILE TO BE TRIED AS AN ADULT

But in its aftermath, the incident has raised several questions. "Not one agency can be acquitted honourably here," says Vijay Kumbhar, a social activist and the Aam Aadmi Party's state vice-president, while indicting bar owners, cops and doctors alike. Sushma Andhare, deputy leader of the Shiv Sena (UBT), even wondered if the juvenile's blood sample was changed "because it contained drugs". Sangeeta Tiwari, vice-president of the state Congress's women's wing, alleged pubs in Pune's tony neighbourhoods were openly flouting the 1.30 am deadline in connivance with the state excise and police officials.

Meanwhile, for the families of the victims, the trauma is compounded by a system seemingly rigged to protect perpetrators of means. As Kumbhar asked, "Who will take action against whom when they all are guilty?" The daunting quest for accountability and justice looms. ■



By M.G. Arun

In a move that will provide a significant economic cushion to the next Union finance minister, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on May 22 announced a record Rs 2.11 lakh crore transfer of its surplus money for FY24 to the central government. The amount is 62 per cent higher than the previous record of Rs 1.76 lakh crore transferred in August 2019, and nearly 2.5 times the Rs 87,416 crore in FY23.

The bonanza from the central bank—twice the Rs 1.02 lakh crore estimated by the Centre in this year's interim budget, including dividends from banks and financial institutions—came as a big relief to the jittery stock markets during election time. Following the announcement, the benchmark BSE Sensex gained 1,196.98 points, or 1.61 per cent, on May 23, to close at 75,418.04, its all-time closing high.

Although the details of the surplus payout will be known only once the RBI's annual report for FY24 is made public, experts say it would have come from higher interest income led by a rise in both global as well as domestic yields, and gains from the RBI's forex reserves. The surplus, the RBI said, was calculated based on the economic capital framework